

Demons at Work

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First Edition

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“One must imagine Sisyphus happy.”

Albert Camus, *The Myth of Sisyphus*

(1942)

For everyone who went back to work on Monday.

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On Paper

On paper, it is not a remarkable assignment.

The file is on my desk when I come in. Someone has dropped it there during the off-shift, which means Intake has a preference about when I look at it and does not want to say so in writing. I note the preference and put the file where I would have put it anyway, in the middle of the blotter, and sit down.

The lights in this corridor of the office hum at a frequency that is not quite fluorescent and not quite anything else. Facilities has been notified. The lights have not changed.

The file is standard Intake format. Cover sheet, subject profile, environmental survey, proposed escalation schedule, performance benchmarks, my signature block in the lower right corner where I am expected to agree that I have read the file and accept the case. I do not sign anything yet. Signing is the last thing you do. If you sign at the front of the process, Management learns to expect it, and then they stop respecting the distinction between read and accepted, and you wind up signing for things you have not read. I learned this once. I did not need to learn it twice.

I flip to the subject profile.

Subject: male, 55, widower. Retired. Sole resident of a single-family dwelling. Religious affiliation: none on record. Church attendance: none on record. Recent significant loss: spouse, deceased 10 months, ALS.

I look at the religious affiliation line for a while.

The stated objective of any atmospheric haunting, per the Operations Manual (seventh edition, Chapter 4, Section 2, subsection “Purpose”), is to erode the subject’s spiritual defenses through sustained environmental dread, leading to a crisis of faith, leading to rejec-

tion of divine protection, leading to a harvestable soul. That is the pipeline. That is what we are for.

My subject does not appear to have spiritual defenses. He does not attend church. He has no religious affiliation. He is not, as far as Intake can tell, protected by anything except a deadbolt and a recently serviced smoke detector.

There is no field on the intake form for “subject does not believe in the thing we need him to reject.” There is a field for “low religious engagement,” which is what Intake has checked, and which is supposed to indicate an easier case. Low defenses. Quick timeline. High likelihood of favorable Soul Outcome. I am not sure how you produce a favorable Soul Outcome with a subject who does not appear to have a relationship with God to sever, but the form does not have a field for that either, and this is not a problem I am going to solve at my desk on a Tuesday morning.

In the notes column someone has written, in Intake shorthand, *caregiver background; expect low avoidance, high baseline fatigue.*

I reread the caregiver note. I appreciate whoever wrote it. Most Intake officers do not think about baseline fatigue. They look at the loss column and assume grief does the work for them. They have never worked a caregiver subject. A caregiver subject has already spent three years learning to sleep through terror. They have been woken up at three in the morning by real things. A floor creak is not terror to them. A floor creak is a normal Tuesday.

I make a note in my margin pad: *adjust Phase 1 expectations. Ambient floor will need to be below normal-Tuesday level before any wrongness reads at all.*

I flip to the proposed escalation schedule. Intake has pre-filled it from the standard template: Week 1, environmental conditioning. Week 2, localized manifestation. Week 3, direct interface. Week 4, escalated confrontation. Week 5, resolution pressure.

I have seen this template four hundred times. I do not know who wrote it. I suspect it was written by someone who has never conducted a field haunting, because “direct interface” in week three is aggressive by any reasonable standard. Direct interface in week three is what Apparitions does. Apparitions shows up, makes a face, and leaves. It is the equivalent of shouting at someone in a parking lot and calling it persuasion.

I cross out the week three entry and write in *sustained ambient pressure; consolidate Phase 1 and 2 gains*. I do this with every case file. Nobody has ever noticed. I am beginning to suspect nobody reads these after I sign them.

I flip to performance benchmarks. Fear Index target: 7.2 (sustained). Timeline adherence: 90%. Collateral Awareness: keep below 15%. Soul Outcome: positive.

I do not know what a Fear Index of 7.2 means. I do not know what a Fear Index of 7.2 is measured against. I have asked. The answer involves a calibration document that references a second calibration document that references a regional standards meeting from 1987 that nobody has the minutes for. Somewhere in that chain of references is presumably a human being who was exactly 7.2 afraid, against whom all subsequent fear is measured, and I would like to meet them, because I have questions.

I sign it.

I flip to environmental.

The dwelling is a single-story bungalow, 1923, original hardwood, original plaster, original windows (storm-upgraded), an attic accessed by a pull-down ladder in the hallway, a basement with an exterior entrance, and a back yard with a garden that has not been tended in ten months but, per the surveyor's note, still has structure. Three bedrooms, one converted to a home office, one converted to a sickroom and not yet reconverted. Acoustic survey attached.

I do not open the acoustic survey yet. I am being disciplined. I am reading the file in order.

The sickroom line catches me because sickrooms are environmental features I know how to work with. They do not require supernatural intervention. They require letting the room do what the room already wants to do. The adjustment furniture generates its own wrongness. A grab bar on a hallway wall does not belong there and the human eye knows it even when the human mind has forgotten. A raised toilet seat in a bathroom without a patient is a loud object. I have worked sickroom subjects before. They go quickly.

But this one is ten months post. Most of the medical equipment will be gone by now. The subject will have packed most of it up or donated it. What remains will be the things the subject could not bring himself to move. Those are the ones I want.

The window behind my desk shows something different today. I do not look at it. I am looking at photographs.

I flip to the environmental survey's photograph insert.

There are four photographs. Two exterior, two interior. I look at the exteriors first. The house is painted a color I do not have a name for, between gray and green, with cream trim. Front porch with a swing. A hedge along one side. A maple in the front yard that is bare in the photograph, which means the survey was done in winter. The house sits back from a quiet street in a grid of similar houses. Old neighborhood. The kind of street that hasn't had a new house built on it in eighty years.

I look at the interior photographs.

The first is a living room. Hardwood floor, high ceiling for a bungalow, a fireplace with a mantel, a pair of armchairs facing slightly away from each other in a configuration that means they were once facing each other and someone has moved one, built-in bookshelves on either side of the fireplace, a standing lamp, a braided rug, a coffee table with a coaster but no cup. On the mantel, a photograph I cannot see the detail of. Above the mantel, an empty nail.

The second is a hallway. Hardwood, runner rug, a grab bar installed on the left-hand wall at about hip height, bolted into a stud. A doorway open at the end of the hall showing a bed made with a white quilt. A framed print on the wall too small to make out. A light fixture on the ceiling I can make out well enough to know that it is original to the house and has not been rewired since roughly the Truman administration.

I sit with the photographs for a moment.

Then I go back to the first one and look at the bookshelves.

Built in, flanking the fireplace, floor to ceiling. Even in the survey photograph, even at this resolution, I can count the shelves. Six on each side. And I can tell that they are full and that the books are arranged by a person, not by an aesthetic. I can tell because the bindings do not match. Paperbacks and hardcovers together. A few reference volumes on the bottom shelves, the way someone puts the heavy books down where the weight belongs. On one of the shelves, a book is lying flat on top of the other books, which is what happens when a book is being read and there is no bookmark handy and someone puts it down in a

hurry meaning to come back.

I do not know what the book is. That is not what I am looking at.

I am looking at the acoustics.

A bookshelf that tall, full of that many books, in a room with a hardwood floor and plaster walls and a fireplace, is a room that has been accidentally tuned. Books dampen high frequencies and let low frequencies through. A room with a wall of books on each side of a central feature does not echo. It absorbs the top end. Which means anything I do in that room at the bass end, anything below about 200 hertz, anything at the register of a house settling, will be audible without being locatable. It will arrive everywhere at once. The subject will not be able to point to a direction and say *the sound is coming from over there*. The sound will be coming from the room.

I have been waiting my entire career for a room like this.

I sign the acceptance block at the bottom of the cover sheet. My designation goes on the signature line. Tertius Gradus, Atmospheric Hauntings, Operative 47-C. Colleagues call me Tert. Management calls me by whichever form of address gets them the response they want. I am not in the habit of correcting either.

I walk the signed file over to Intake's pickup window. There is no one at the window. There never is. I put the file in the tray and I go back to my desk and I open my own calendar and I block out the first five weeks of a standard atmospheric cycle.

Then I sit for a moment looking at the calendar, at the five weeks stretched across it in clean bureaucratic gray, and I think about bookshelves.

Hat

I stop at the break room on my way back from Intake. The coffee is the wrong temperature. It is always the wrong temperature. Not hot, not cold. Not lukewarm in the way that implies it was once hot and cooled. Lukewarm in a way that suggests it was manufactured at this exact temperature specifically to disappoint. I drink it anyway.

The new hire is in the break room. I know they are the new hire because they are sitting at a table with a copy of the Operations Manual open in front of them, which means they are either on their first week or they have been written up for a protocol violation and are being punished with the required corrective reading. Nobody else opens the Operations Manual voluntarily. I took mine out of the shrink-wrap in 2004 to look up whether I could expense a particular type of chalk. I could not. I have not opened it since.

“Excuse me,” the new hire says. “Can I ask you something?”

This is a question I have learned to be cautious with. The things new hires want to ask range from procedurally answerable (“where is the transit desk?”) to philosophically catastrophic (“what is the actual mechanism by which fear produces a harvestable soul?”). There is no way to tell which kind you are getting until you have already said yes.

“Depends,” I say.

“Why do we do the flickering lights thing?”

I sip my coffee. It is exactly the temperature I expect.

“Flickering disrupts the visual baseline,” I say. “Humans process environmental continuity as a safety signal. When a light source stutters, even briefly, the visual cortex flags it before the conscious mind can decide whether to worry. That is your opening. You are not scaring them with the flicker. You are telling their nervous system that the environment is

unstable. The fear comes later, from what they do with that information.”

The new hire nods. She has a pen out. She is taking notes in the margins of the Operations Manual.

“But what does that do for the pipeline?” she says. “Like, how does making a light flicker lead to a harvestable soul?”

There it is. The pivot from procedurally answerable to philosophically catastrophic, right where I said it would be, and I walked into it anyway.

“That is above my operational scope,” I say, which is the phrase Management uses when they do not want to answer a question. I have picked it up the way people pick up phrases from the organization they work in, without deciding to and without being proud of it.

The new hire writes this down too. I watch her write it. She writes it in the margin next to a paragraph that presumably already contains the official answer, which means either she has read the official answer and found it insufficient, or she has not read it yet and is collecting opinions first. I do not know which is worse.

“What about salt?” she says.

“It is fine on eggs,” I say. “Overused in most other contexts.”

She looks at me. I sip my coffee.

“Holy water?”

“Depends on who blessed it. Nobody knows why. Controlled studies have been proposed. HR rejected them.”

“Crucifixes?”

“Mildly irritating at close range. Like a bright light. Older ones are worse. Nobody knows why that either.”

“Sage?”

“The smoke is unpleasant. So is all smoke. The humans who burn it tend to open windows, which affects air currents, which can interfere with thermal work. The window is the problem, not the sage.”

“Iron?”

I pause. “Iron is uncomfortable. Route around it.”

“So iron actually works.”

“Iron is uncomfortable,” I say. “I did not say it works. I said I route around it. I also route around traffic and dogs.”

“Dogs?”

“Dogs notice you. They do not care. They look at you and go back to sleep. Junior operatives find this unnerving. It is not a countermeasure. It is a dog.”

She is writing very quickly.

“What is your name?” I say.

“Eighth Meridian,” she says. “Atmospheric Hauntings, Operative 112-F. People have been calling me Meri.”

“They would,” I say.

I finish my coffee and put the cup in the designated area, which is a counter next to a sink that nobody has ever seen running water come out of. The cups accumulate there until they do not, which implies someone or something collects them, but I have never witnessed this and I am not curious enough to investigate.

I take the lower corridor toward transit. It is longer today than it was yesterday. This happens. Somewhere between the break room and the stairwell, I pass someone from Apparitions. I know they are from Apparitions because they are adjusting their face in the hallway mirror. Apparitions operatives spend a lot of time on their faces. They have a whole department workshop on it: “Facial Presentation for Maximum Startle.” I attended it once, by accident, having misread a room number. The content was exactly what you would expect from a department that believes the key to damnation is making the right expression at the right moment. There were slides. There was a ranking system. Someone had strong opinions about whether the eyes or the mouth delivers more impact per millisecond of exposure. I left during a debate about jawlines.

The operative in the mirror catches my eye and nods. I nod back. We do not understand each other’s work, but the nod costs nothing.

The transit desk is at the end of the lower corridor, behind a door marked 1-14B. The desk itself is unoccupied. There is a sign-out clipboard on a chain bolted to the wall, a stack of transit forms in a plastic tray, and a second door on the far side of the room, also

marked 1-14B, which would be confusing if you thought about it, so I do not.

I fill in a transit form. Name, designation, case number, destination address, estimated shift duration, expected return. The form has not been updated since at least the 1990s. There is a field for “mode of concealment (circle one):” followed by options that include “spectral translucency,” “environmental camouflage,” and “hat.” I circle hat.

I slide the form through the slot. I open the far door.

The house is at the end of a quiet street in an old grid neighborhood, and I am standing on the sidewalk across from it in late-afternoon light. The maple in the front yard is not bare now. It has leaves. Spring has arrived since the survey photographs were taken. The house is exactly the color between gray and green. The swing on the front porch moves slightly in the wind.

I do not go in yet. The first visit is observation. You do not begin a haunting by doing something. You begin it by learning where you are.

The Canvas

The house is better than the photographs.

I come in through the back door, which is unlocked. The subject is not home. His car is not in the driveway. I checked before I crossed the street. Entering while the subject is present on a first visit is not against protocol, but it is bad practice. You want the first impression to be yours alone, without the noise of a person living in the space.

The kitchen is ordinary. Linoleum floor, which is unfortunate. Linoleum absorbs everything and returns nothing. It is the acoustic equivalent of shouting into a pillow. Whoever renovated this kitchen did not consult a haunting professional, but nobody ever does. I note the contents of the counter: a coffee maker, a single mug drying upside down on a towel, a bowl with two bananas going brown, a stack of mail that has not been opened. The refrigerator hums. It is a different hum from the office lights, but it has a similar quality of being the only sound in a room that should have more.

I walk through to the living room.

The bookshelves are everything I hoped.

Floor to ceiling, flanking the fireplace, exactly as the photographs showed. But photographs do not capture acoustics. I stop in the middle of the room and listen. Not to anything. To the room itself, to the shape of silence in it. The books absorb the top end just as I predicted. The room is quiet in a way that has texture. I rap my knuckle against the hardwood floor. Once. The sound is clean, immediate, and then it is gone. There is no ring, no sustain. I do it again near the fireplace. Same. The room eats the top and lets the bass through.

I have been in a lot of houses. Some of them were good. This one is something else.

The armchairs face slightly away from each other. I noted this in the photograph. Up close, the geometry is clearer: one has been moved about eight inches to the left, just enough to no longer face the other directly. The cushion on the unmoved chair has a deep imprint. The moved one does not. Someone sat in one chair for a long time. Then someone moved the other. Nobody has sat in the moved one since.

Above the mantel, the empty nail. The photograph on the mantel itself shows two people, but the light from the window makes it hard to see details and I do not pick it up. I am not here to learn the subject's history. I am here to learn the room.

On the bookshelf, third shelf from the top on the right side, a book lies flat on top of the other books. The same one I noticed in the survey photograph. It is a thick paperback with a cracked spine and a bookmark about two-thirds through. Everything else on these shelves has been standing upright for years. This book has been taken down recently and put back, or taken down and put back many times. I do not pick it up. It is not relevant to the work.

I walk the hallway. The grab bar is on the left wall at hip height, bolted into a stud, painted over once in the same off-white as the wall. Nobody has grabbed it recently.

At the end of the hallway, the door to the sickroom is closed.

I open it.

The hospital bed is gone. The floor has a rectangular depression where the frame sat for at least two years, based on how the hardwood has compressed. The curtains are sheer, the kind a caregiver hangs to let light in during the day without the neighbors seeing in at night. A nightstand is pushed against the wall with a glass of water on it. The water has evaporated to about a third. Nobody has touched it.

The room smells stale. Under the staleness there is something clinical I recognize: the residue of antiseptic cleaners, the kind used around medical equipment. It has soaked into the baseboards. Most people would not notice it. The subject probably does not notice it anymore. I notice it because noticing what humans have stopped noticing is the entire job.

I close the door.

The bathroom is across the hall. The raised toilet seat is still installed. The medicine

cabinet is full of labeled prescription bottles, most of them expired. I read a few of the labels. They are not relevant to the work. I read them anyway.

I go back to the living room and sit down in the armchair with the imprint. I am not doing anything. I am letting the house settle around me, letting my presence become part of the room's acoustic profile so that when I begin the work, I know what the baseline sounds like with me in it.

The house creaks. Not from me. Houses creak. Old ones especially, in the afternoon, when the temperature differential between the sun-facing wall and the interior creates expansion stress in the joists. This is the sound the subject hears every day. This is the sound I need to be indistinguishable from, and then distinguishable from, in exactly the right way at exactly the right moment.

Phase 1 will be floor-level. Sub-threshold. I will use the house's own sounds and introduce variations so small that the subject's conscious mind cannot identify them but his nervous system can. He will not think something is wrong. He will feel slightly less comfortable than he did yesterday, and he will not know why.

This is the part of the work I love. Not the scaring. The calibration.

A car pulls into the driveway.

I go still. Not invisible. I am already concealed. Still in the way you go still when the subject of your attention has arrived and the observation begins.

A key in the front door. The lock turns. The door opens and closes. Footsteps on hardwood: a man who has not yet taken off his shoes because the first thing he does is put his keys on the hook and his bag on the chair by the door. I hear both of these things happen. Then the shoes come off. The footsteps become quieter and move into the kitchen. The refrigerator opens and closes. A glass of water from the tap. The footsteps come back through the hallway, past the closed sickroom door without pausing, and into the living room.

He sits down in the other armchair. The one without the imprint. The one that was moved.

He does not sit in his wife's chair.

I am three feet from him, in the chair that was hers.

Fourteen Minutes



The subject goes to bed at eleven-fourteen.

I know this because I have been in the house since six, positioned in the hallway between the bathroom and the sickroom door, and I have been tracking his movements by sound for five hours. This is not exciting work. It is necessary work. Phase 1 requires a complete baseline of the subject's evening routine: when he eats, when he watches television, when he moves from room to room, when the lights go off. You need the baseline before you can introduce variation, the same way a musician needs to hear the instrument in tune before they can play it out of tune on purpose.

He ate dinner at seven. Something involving a pot and a cutting board and the sound of a single plate being set on a table. He watched television from seven-forty until nine-thirty. I could hear it through the wall but could not tell what it was. He washed the pot and the plate and the cutting board. He brushed his teeth. He walked past the sickroom door without pausing, which is what he did the first time I was here and what I expect he does every time. He turned off the hallway light. He went to bed. The bedroom light stayed on for another twenty minutes and then went off.

Eleven-fourteen.

I wait another forty minutes. You do not begin until the subject is in deep sleep. This is not a guess. Breathing patterns change. The house changes around a sleeping person: it becomes the only thing making sound. A sleeping human generates a rhythm, and after forty minutes that rhythm has stabilized. The house is now the subject's instrument. My job is to play it.

I start in the basement.

The basement is where the joists are exposed, which means I can see the structural skeleton of the house. Every creak the subject hears on the floor above originates from one of these joists expanding or contracting against its bearing point. The house has a pattern. It creaks at predictable intervals based on the temperature curve through the night: the wood contracts as the exterior cools, the contraction generates stress at the joints, and the stress releases as a sound the subject has been hearing every night for twenty years.

I am going to make that sound happen six minutes early.

Not tonight. Tonight I am mapping. I am lying on the concrete floor of the basement with my hand on a joist, feeling the thermal contraction through the wood, counting the interval between stress events. This is the part of the job nobody talks about in briefings, because it is not dramatic and it does not photograph well for the departmental newsletter. There is no departmental newsletter. But if there were, this would not make the cover.

The interval between creaks on this joist is roughly fourteen minutes. The next joist over is closer to nine. The one nearest the living room, directly under the bookshelf wall, has an irregular pattern that I will need two more nights to map.

I spend four hours in the basement. The concrete is not comfortable. I have never filed the form for this, and I suspect nobody has.

At three in the morning I come upstairs. The subject is still asleep. I can hear him breathing through the bedroom door, which he does not close all the way. People who have been caregivers often sleep with doors open. It is a habit that outlasts its reason.

I stand in the living room in the dark. The room is different at night. The books on the shelves are dark shapes. The fireplace is a black rectangle. The two armchairs are silhouettes, one facing slightly away from the other. The empty nail above the mantel catches the light from the street lamp outside in a way that makes it the brightest point in the room. I did not plan this. The house did it on its own.

I do one thing before I leave. A small thing. I have been in the house for nine hours without introducing any change to the environment, which is correct for a first work night. But I allow myself one small adjustment, something so minor it barely qualifies.

I shift the thermostat down two degrees.

Not enough for the subject to wake up cold. Not enough for him to notice in the

morning and check the setting. Just enough that when his body moves through the hallway at six a.m. on the way to the bathroom, the air will be slightly different from yesterday, and the difference will register below the threshold of conscious thought as a sensation he cannot name and will not remember having.

This is what Phase 1 is. Not fear. Not dread. A whisper of wrongness so faint that the subject's only response is to feel, for a moment, slightly less at home in the place where he lives.

I let myself out the back door. The sky is turning gray. A cat on the porch across the street watches me without interest, which is typical. Animals do not react to us the way the movies suggest. They notice us the same way they notice a change in the weather: briefly, and then they go back to what they were doing.

Good Acoustics



My supervisor is designated Primus Ordinatus, which everyone shortens to Prim. It suits them. Prim is, technically, several hundred demons operating as a single administrative entity. This is not uncommon at the management level. It explains the thoroughness.

Prim stops by my desk on Tuesday morning. This means either there is a scheduling conflict or they have read one of my shift reports. Both would be unusual. Prim is carrying a clipboard. They always are. The mug says WORLD'S BEST and nothing else. It was issued to all middle management during a morale initiative whose purpose and origin nobody remembers.

"Tert," they say. "Do you have a minute?"

I have exactly as many minutes as Prim needs me to have, because the question is rhetorical and the correct answer to a rhetorical question from your supervisor is always the one they already assume.

"Sure," I say.

"I wanted to touch base on forty-seven-C. The new atmospheric."

"All right."

"Intake flagged it as standard. Low religious engagement, caregiver background, single-occupant dwelling. How are you finding the environmental parameters?"

"Good acoustics," I say.

Prim writes this down. I watch them write it. They write "good acoustics" on a clipboard in a column I cannot see the heading of. There is a form for this conversation. This is not a casual check-in. This is a documented Week 1 Field Assessment. Someone in Compliance decided these needed to exist. There is now a paper trail for the fact that I said

“good acoustics” to my supervisor on a Tuesday morning.

“And the Phase 1 benchmarks. Are we on track for the week-one Fear Index baseline?”

The Fear Index baseline for week one is a number pulled from a template that has no relationship to anything happening in the house. But it is on Prim’s form, and Prim needs to fill in the field.

“On track,” I say.

“Good. I see you modified the week-three escalation protocol. Direct interface felt premature?”

Someone read my modification. It turns out I preferred it when nobody did.

“For a caregiver subject with high baseline fatigue, yes.”

“That is good field judgment. Flag it for the mid-cycle so the reasoning is on record.”

“Done.”

Behind Prim, something in the corridor catches the light in a way that light should not be caught. Neither of us looks at it.

“One more thing. The Soul Outcome projection. Intake has this one at seventy-two percent positive. Any early reads that would adjust that?”

Seventy-two percent positive. For a secular subject with no church attendance, no religious framework, and no apparent relationship with God to sever. Seventy-two percent of what. Measured against what. Calibrated by the same methodology that produced the Fear Index of 7.2, which is calibrated against a meeting from 1987 that nobody has the minutes for. I could explain this to Prim. I have considered it. The explanation would be received, documented on the clipboard, filed, and would change nothing about the number on the form or the form’s existence or Prim’s belief in the form’s utility.

“I will have more data by week two,” I say.

“Perfect,” Prim says. “Keep me posted.”

They leave. The conversation took four minutes. Prim has a completed form, which is what Prim came for, and I am not entirely sure that is the small thing I used to think it was.

On my way to the transit desk I pass Meri in the hallway. She is not carrying the Operations Manual, which is either progress or surrender.

“I read the section,” she says.

I do not need to ask which section. “What did it say?”

“It said the mechanism is well-established and does not require field-level understanding.”

“There you go,” I say.

“That is not an answer.”

“No,” I say.

Six Minutes Early



On Thursday night, I make the first joist creak six minutes early.

I am in the basement with my hand on the beam under the bookshelf wall. I have spent three nights learning its rhythm. At 1:47 a.m., the joist would ordinarily release its next stress event: a low creak that travels through the floor and arrives in the living room and the hallway and the bedroom at slightly different times. The subject has heard this sound every night for twenty years. His body knows when it is coming even if his mind does not.

At 1:41, I apply pressure to the bearing point. Not much. Enough to accelerate the contraction by six minutes. The stress releases. The creak arrives.

It is the same creak. Same frequency, same resonance, same arrival pattern. Nothing about the sound itself is wrong. What is wrong is the timing. The discrepancy is below conscious threshold, but the body keeps its own schedule, and when the schedule is off, the body notices.

From the bedroom, I hear Gordon shift in his sleep. Not wake. Shift. One position adjustment, the kind that happens when the autonomic nervous system receives information it cannot act on and translates it into movement.

I do this three more times before dawn, each on a different joist, each shifted by a different interval. I will see the result in his posture by Friday, in the specific way a person carries themselves when they have slept for eight hours and rested for six.

On Friday night, I run the bathroom tap for two seconds while Gordon is in the hallway. Not long enough to be certain. Just long enough to register from six feet away, where he is walking past the bathroom on his way to bed. He pauses. Two seconds is below

the threshold of certainty. Was the tap on? Is the handle loose? He does not open the bathroom door. He continues to the bedroom. But he paused. A pause is all I need.

I have started thinking of him as Gordon, which the Operations Manual advises against. The Operations Manual has not spent ten days in his house.

On Saturday I introduce a low-frequency vibration in the water pipes, timed to coincide with the house's thermal settling, so that the pipes and the joists produce overlapping sounds that Gordon's nervous system cannot separate. The house no longer has a clean rhythm. It has a complex one, and complexity reads as instability.

On Sunday evening Gordon is sitting in his armchair reading. Not aloud. A different book. He reads a page, sets it down, picks it up again. He cannot concentrate. He stands up and checks the thermostat. It reads sixty-six. He looks at it for a moment. He turns it up to sixty-eight.

He found the thermostat. I will not use it again.

He goes back to his chair. He picks up the book. He reads the same page. After a few minutes he puts it down and goes to the kitchen to make tea. He brings the tea back to the living room. He does not drink it.

I am satisfied with the work.

The Garden

On Tuesday, Gordon goes into the garden.

I was not expecting this. His pattern has been consistent: leave by nine, return by four. Today he does not leave. He eats breakfast, washes the dishes, and stands in the kitchen for a long time looking out the window at the back yard.

The garden is along the back fence. His wife's. I can tell because the structure is intentional: raised beds, a trellis, a stone border. But the maintenance has been nothing for ten months. The beds are overgrown. The trellis has collapsed on one side.

Gordon goes outside and stands at the edge of the garden the way I stood in the living room on my first visit: reading the space, assessing what is here and what could be done with it.

He starts pulling weeds. He does not appear to know what is a weed and what is not. He pulls several things I suspect were planted on purpose. He works for about forty minutes. The raised bed does not look better when he is done. It looks different, which is not the same thing, but he regards it as if it is.

He goes inside, eats lunch standing at the counter, looking out the window at the bed.

He goes back out and works for another hour. He finds the collapsed trellis and tries to fix it. He does not have the right tools or the right knowledge. He props it against the fence in a configuration that will not survive a moderate wind. He steps back. He adjusts one side. He steps back again.

I make a note in my margin pad: *subject engaging with outdoor space; investigate external sound vectors.*

Cancellation



On Wednesday, Gordon's phone rings.

I am in the hallway. He is in the living room. He answers it. I can hear both sides. A woman's voice, warm, familiar. She is asking if he still wants to come to dinner on Saturday. She says the word "everyone" in a way that means a small group of people who know him and have been checking on him since his wife died.

"I think I will sit this one out," Gordon says. "I have not been sleeping well."

This is true. He has not been sleeping well because of me.

The woman on the phone says she understands. She says he should call if he changes his mind. She says they miss him. He says thank you. He says he will call. He hangs up.

He stands in the living room for a moment holding the phone. Then he puts it down and goes to the kitchen to make dinner for one.

I make a note in my margin pad: *subject declining social contact; Phase 2 isolation indicators present.*

Trust the Process

Meri is at my desk when I get back from a shift.

This is not standard. Nobody sits at someone else's desk. There was an incident in 2019 involving a borrowed pen that generated a seven-page Compliance memo on workspace sovereignty. The memo resolved the situation by existing. Meri has either not read it or has decided that her question is worth the breach.

"How do you know when it is working?" she says.

I set my bag down. I do not ask her to move. Escalating a minor boundary issue into a conversation about boundaries would take longer than whatever Meri actually wants to talk about.

"When what is working?"

"The ambient conditioning. Phase 1. You shift the thermostat, you adjust the timing of the house sounds, you introduce sub-threshold variations. How do you know any of it is landing?"

Meri has been reading. Not the Operations Manual. Something useful, which narrows the options considerably. Shift reports, maybe, or the Phase 1 technical supplement that Compliance published in 2011 and nobody acknowledged.

"Behavior changes," I say. "Sleep is the first indicator. Then attention span. Then routine drift: small changes in when the subject eats, when they go to bed, whether they finish tasks they start. You are looking for erosion, not collapse. If the subject collapses, you escalated too fast, and you will be filling out paperwork for the rest of the quarter."

"What does erosion look like?"

"Sunday night my subject made a cup of tea and did not drink it."

Meri considers this. “That could be anything. That could be grief.”

“Yes.”

“So how do you know it was you?”

This is the question. Not the pipeline question from the break room, which was abstract and philosophical. This one is concrete. How do I know my work is having an effect, as opposed to the subject’s grief doing it for me?

The answer is that I do not know. I have no way of distinguishing between ambient unease caused by my interventions and ambient unease caused by being a fifty-five-year-old widower alone in the house where his wife died. The symptoms are identical. The subject’s sleeplessness could be Phase 1 taking hold or it could be Tuesday.

“You learn to trust the process,” I say, which is the second time I have used one of Management’s phrases to avoid answering a question from Meri, and I like it less than I did the first time.

Meri looks at me for a moment. She does not write this one down.

“Thank you,” she says, and leaves.

Revised Protocols

On Wednesday there is a mandatory training. The subject line on the calendar invitation says “Revised Protocols for Environmental Documentation in Non-Standard Dwelling Types.” Attendance is required. The invitation was sent by Compliance.

The training is in the large conference room, which is the room used for events that are too important to skip and too unimportant to prepare for. The chairs are arranged in rows. There is a projector. The projector displays a title slide that contains the full name of the training, the date, a Compliance logo, and the word “Draft” in the lower right corner. The title slide has been on screen for ten minutes. Nobody has advanced past it.

The Compliance officer arrives. They apologize for the projector, which is working correctly. They advance to the second slide. It is a flowchart.

The flowchart describes the process by which a field operative should document environmental conditions in a dwelling that does not conform to standard residential classification. It has fourteen boxes and twenty-three arrows. Several of the arrows point to boxes that say “See Supplemental Flowchart B.” Supplemental Flowchart B is not in the slide deck. The Compliance officer mentions this and says it will be distributed separately.

I look around the room. There are eleven operatives present. Two are from Possessions. One is from Whispers. The rest are Hauntings. Nobody is taking notes except Meri, who is in the second row with her pen out, writing in what appears to be a new notebook. She has graduated from the margins of the Operations Manual.

The Compliance officer spends fifteen minutes explaining a change to Field 14 on Form 7-C. Field 14 previously required the operative to record the dwelling’s construction material. It now requires the operative to record the dwelling’s construction material and

its acoustic classification, which is a category I have never seen on a form before and which, if it had existed six years ago, would have saved me the trouble of writing “good acoustics” on a clipboard during a Week 1 Field Assessment.

I have been filling in Field 14 without the acoustic classification for six years. Either I have been making an error nobody noticed, or the field has been redefined and my previous entries are now retroactively incomplete. The Compliance officer does not address which of these is the case.

A Possessions operative raises a hand and asks what acoustic classification means in the context of a human body, which is where Possessions does most of its work. The Compliance officer says that is an excellent question and refers them to the supplemental flowchart.

Meri raises her hand.

“If the acoustic classification affects the Fear Index calculation, should we retroactively adjust the baseline projections for active cases?”

The room is quiet for a moment. The Compliance officer looks at the flowchart. The flowchart does not contain an answer to this question. The flowchart does not contain the word “retroactively.”

“That would be a question for your supervisor,” the Compliance officer says.

The training ends. I have been in this room for forty-five minutes. I know one new thing: Field 14 on Form 7-C now has a second component. I will fill it in. I have always filled in the fields.

Wednesday Night



Week three. The haunting is at technical peak.

I have been in this house for seventeen days and I know it the way a musician knows an instrument. I know which joist creaks at what interval. I know how the pipes resonate against the foundation walls. I know that the attic ladder, if released by half an inch from its catch, produces a sound at 2 a.m. that is indistinguishable from a footstep on the landing. I know where to stand in the hallway to be visible in the bathroom mirror for exactly one-quarter second when the subject passes. I know the house's thermal rhythms, its air currents, the way sound travels from the basement to the bedroom through the gap under the sickroom door.

I have not used the gap under the sickroom door. Some things you hold in reserve.

Gordon is not sleeping well. This is evident in everything: the pace of his footsteps in the morning, the length of his showers, the number of times he reheats the same cup of coffee before giving up on it. He has started leaving lights on in rooms he is not in, which is a Phase 2 indicator so classical it is literally in the manual. A subject who leaves lights on is a subject whose relationship with darkness has shifted. They may not know why. They do not need to.

On Wednesday night I produce my best work of the assignment.

It is a sequence. Not a single event. A three-part escalation over ninety minutes, using the bookshelf wall, the bathroom tap, and a thermal pocket I have been cultivating in the hallway outside the bedroom since week one. The sequence is designed so that each element arrives just as the previous one has faded below threshold: the creak, then silence; the tap, then silence; then the cold spot in the hallway, timed to coincide with Gordon's

first REM cycle, so that when his body registers the temperature drop it incorporates the sensation into whatever he is dreaming and the dream turns.

This is atmospheric work at the level I have always known I was capable of and have rarely had a canvas for. The timing is precise. The layering is clean. The house performs exactly as I have taught it to perform. If the departmental newsletter existed, this would make the cover.

Gordon wakes at 3:47. He does not get out of bed. He lies still for several minutes. I can hear his breathing from the hallway: elevated, then deliberate, then controlled. He is calming himself down. A subject who has to work to calm down is a subject whose baseline has been successfully lowered.

He gets up at four and goes to the kitchen. He does not turn on the hall light. I note this. A subject who was leaving lights on but now walks through darkness has either habituated or entered a state of fatigue where the effort of reaching for the switch exceeds the comfort of the light. Both are useful.

He makes coffee. It is four in the morning and he is making coffee because I woke him and he has decided that going back to sleep is not something he can do right now. He stands at the counter in the dark kitchen with the coffee maker running and the only light coming from the microwave display, and he looks out the window at the back yard where the garden is.

And he laughs.

Not loudly. Not at anything I can identify. A short sound, almost a breath, that starts as something else and becomes a laugh halfway through. He shakes his head once. He is laughing at himself, or at the situation, or at something I am not equipped to observe.

The laugh does not fit the ambient environment I have spent three weeks building. It is evidence of something inside Gordon that my work has not touched.

I stand in the hallway and I listen to him pour his coffee and I do not make a note in my margin pad.

Middlemarch

Sunday evening.

I am in the hallway, positioned for the night shift. Gordon has eaten dinner, washed the dishes, watched television until nine-thirty. The routine has not changed in three weeks. What has changed is the quality of his attention: he moves through the house more carefully now, checking rooms before he enters them, pausing at thresholds. This is my work. I know it is my work because I built the conditions that produced it. Or it is his grief. I have no way to tell.

At nine-forty he turns off the television. He does not go to the bedroom. He goes to the bookshelf.

He stands in front of it for a moment. Then he reaches up to the third shelf on the right and takes down the thick paperback that has been lying flat on top of the others since before I arrived. The one with the cracked spine. The one I noted in the survey photograph and again on my first visit and dismissed as not relevant to the work.

The cover says *Middlemarch*. I have seen it on the shelf for three weeks without reading the title.

He carries the book to his armchair and sits down. He opens it to the bookmark, about two-thirds through. He reads for a moment in silence, finding his place.

Then he begins to read aloud.

Gordon has not read aloud on any previous evening I have observed. This is a new pattern. I note it the way I note all new patterns, as data, as a behavioral event to be logged in the margin pad.

But his voice is different when he reads aloud. I have been listening to Gordon for

three weeks: the way he talks to himself while cooking, the way he answers the phone, the way he says goodnight to no one before he turns off the bedroom light. This is not those voices. This is the voice of a man who spent thirty years reading to rooms full of teenagers who did not want to be there and who learned to make them want to be there. It has warmth and pacing and a specific attention to the weight of each sentence, the care of a voice being used for someone else's benefit.

I catch a fragment of what he is reading: "... the element of tragedy which lies in the very fact of frequency..." I am not listening to the words. I am listening to the voice.

He is not reading to the room. He is reading to someone who is not here, in the voice he would use if she were, and the distinction between those two things is the largest thing I have encountered in this house.

He reads for about forty minutes. I do not time it exactly. I am not, for these forty minutes, timing anything.

He pauses between chapters. During the pauses he does not put the book down. He holds it open, as if the conversation is only resting.

When he finishes he puts the bookmark back, closes the book, and places it flat on top of the others on the third shelf. This is how it looked in the survey photograph. This is how it has looked every time I have been in this room.

He turns off the lamp. He goes to bed. He closes the bedroom door most of the way but not all the way, the way a person does when they have spent years listening for sounds from another room.

I stay in the hallway for a while.

The Report

The shift report takes four minutes to write. It has always taken four minutes. The form has not changed. The fields are the same fields: date, case number, shift duration, activities performed, environmental adjustments, subject behavioral observations, Phase assessment.

I write: *Subject exhibited new behavioral pattern: vocalized reading (solo, approx. 40 min). Source text unidentified. No escalation response required. Ambient conditioning maintained per schedule. No contact.*

This is accurate. Everything in the report happened. Nothing in the report did not happen. The report contains all of the relevant data and none of what the data was like.

I file it. I get coffee. It is the wrong temperature. I drink it anyway.

Meri is not in the break room. I notice this, which is new. I do not usually track who is and is not in a room I have entered for coffee.

On the counter next to the sink, someone has put a potted plant. The plant is dead. It has been dead for some time. Someone is watering it anyway. I have seen the water stains.

I go back to my desk. The window behind it shows the same thing it showed yesterday, which is unusual in its own way. I do not look at it closely.

I sit at my desk for a while.

Eleven Minutes

I go back to the house on Monday.

The work does not change. I want to be clear about this. The work does not change because the work is the work, and what happened on Sunday night does not alter the fact that I have an assignment with a timeline and an escalation schedule and a set of professional standards I have spent my career developing. The house still needs to do what I have taught it to do. Gordon still needs to feel what the Phase schedule says he needs to feel.

I produce two sound events on Monday night, both at the bass register, both timed to his first sleep cycle. They are technically clean. On Tuesday I advance the thermal gradient in the hallway by another half-degree, targeting the space between the bedroom and the bathroom. On Wednesday I introduce a new element: a vibration in the attic ladder mechanism that produces a sound like a footstep on the landing, once, at 2:14 a.m., the time of night when the brain is most susceptible to interpreting ambiguous sounds as human presence.

This is good work. This is the work I am here to do.

On Wednesday night, after the attic sound, Gordon wakes. I hear him sit up in bed. I hear the silence that follows, which is the silence of a person listening, deciding whether what they heard was real.

The schedule says: follow the attic sound with a second event within four minutes. This is the escalation principle. You do not let the subject settle. You layer. The second event confirms the first and collapses the possibility that it was imagined.

I wait eleven minutes.

I tell myself this is because the thermal pocket in the hallway has not reached optimal

differential. This is true. It is also true that I could have used a different second event, one that did not depend on the thermal pocket, and I chose not to.

Gordon lies back down. He does not go back to sleep for a long time, but he lies down, and the quality of his breathing changes from listening to waiting to something that is not quite rest but is closer to rest than listening was. Outside, through the bedroom window, a car passes on the street. Its headlights move across the ceiling. Gordon watches them.

I file the shift report on Thursday morning. Under activities I write: *Two sound events Mon. Thermal advancement Tues. Attic mechanism Wed, single event, 2:14. Follow-up delayed due to thermal conditions. No contact.*

“Delayed due to thermal conditions” is not a lie. It is a true statement. I could have used a different follow-up, one that did not depend on the thermal pocket. I chose not to.

Two Cups



On Saturday afternoon, Gordon calls the woman from the dinner invitation.

I am in the hallway. He is in the kitchen. He dials the number from memory, which means he has called it before, many times, over many years.

“Helen,” he says. “Are you free tomorrow? I thought you might like to come for tea.”

She says yes. He says two o’clock. He hangs up and stands in the kitchen for a moment, and then he does something I have not seen him do in four weeks of observation: he cleans the living room.

Not because it is dirty. Because someone is coming. He straightens the books on the coffee table. He washes the mug that has been drying on the counter and puts it away. He takes out a second mug. He puts a kettle on the stove to test whether it still works. It does. He puts it back.

Sunday at two, Helen arrives. She is roughly Gordon’s age. She brings something in a container. They sit in the living room, in the two armchairs, and they talk.

I am in the hallway. I cannot hear the conversation clearly. I can hear the quality of Gordon’s voice, and it is the voice from the readings: warm, unhurried, shaped for someone else’s benefit. Helen’s voice is similar. They are two people who have known each other for a long time sitting in a room full of books having a conversation that does not need to be loud.

She stays for an hour. When she leaves, Gordon walks her to the door. He says something I cannot hear. She laughs. He closes the door and goes to the kitchen and washes the cups. Two cups.

He puts them both away.

Mid-Cycle

Prim schedules the mid-cycle review for Thursday.

I know it is a mid-cycle review because it is on the calendar as “Mid-Cycle Performance Assessment (Field),” and because it takes place in a room with a door, which the week-one check-in did not. The room has a table, two chairs, and a motivational poster that says EXCELLENCE IS A HABIT. Nobody has removed the poster. Nobody enters this room voluntarily.

“Tert,” Prim says, sitting down with the clipboard. The clipboard has more pages than it did during the week-one check-in. They have tabbed the sections. “Thank you for coming in.”

I was not given a choice about coming in, but I say “of course” because this is the script and deviating from the script would add time without adding clarity.

“I have been reviewing your shift reports for forty-seven-C. Weeks one through four.” Prim opens the clipboard to a tabbed section. “The numbers look strong. Timeline adherence is at ninety-two percent. Fear Index progression is on curve. Collateral Awareness is well below threshold.”

“Good,” I say, because this is where Prim pauses and expects a response, and “good” is the one that lets them continue.

“I am noticing a pattern in your follow-up intervals, though. Weeks three and four, you have several entries where the secondary event was delayed. Thermal conditions, mostly.” Prim looks up from the clipboard. “Is there an environmental factor I should flag for Intake? Something about the dwelling’s thermal profile that is affecting your layering schedule?”

Prim noticed. Prim reads the forms and Prim noticed that my follow-up intervals

changed after week two. This is what careful reading does. This is what I was concerned about when Prim read my week-three modification, and it is exactly as uncomfortable now as it was then, and for different reasons.

“The house has complex thermal behavior,” I say. “Original construction, plaster walls, uneven insulation. Some nights the conditions are not optimal for layered events.”

This is true. Every word of it is true. None of these facts is the reason my follow-up intervals changed, and all of them are sufficient to satisfy the field on the form.

Prim writes this down. “I will note it as an environmental variable. If it persists into week five, we may want Intake to do a supplemental thermal survey.”

A supplemental thermal survey of a house I have mapped to the individual joist. But the process recommends a survey, and so a survey will be recommended.

“That would be fine,” I say.

“One more thing. The Soul Outcome projection. We are still tracking seventy-two percent. Any movement?”

The seventy-two percent was never attached to anything that moves.

“I will have a clearer picture by case closure,” I say.

“Good.” Prim closes the clipboard. “The work looks solid, Tert. Keep it up.”

They leave. Prim noticed the pattern and asked the right question in the wrong language. The form gave them the only answer it had.

The Doorway

Week four. Direct manifestation.

This is the phase I have been building toward since the first night in the basement. Everything before this was preparation: the ambient wrongness, the sub-threshold erosion of Gordon's relationship with the house's predictability. All of it was foundation. Week four is when the foundation becomes visible.

The protocol calls for a visual element. Not a full apparition. Atmospheric Hauntings uses visibility the way a painter uses shadow: not as the subject, but as the thing that gives the subject depth. A shape at the edge of perception. A figure in peripheral vision that is gone when you turn. A reflection in a surface that shows something the room does not contain.

The technique is positioning. You have to know exactly where the subject's eye will be, and when, and for how long. The bathroom mirror, for instance: if I stand in the hallway at a specific distance from the door frame while Gordon is brushing his teeth, there is a quarter-second window when his eye, tracking his own reflection, will pass through the angle where the hallway is visible behind him. A quarter second. If I am in position, he will see something. If I am not, he will not. The margin is zero.

On Thursday night I set up for the mirror.

Gordon goes to the bathroom at 11:08. I am in the hallway, six feet back from the door frame, at the angle I have calculated from three weeks of observation. The bathroom light is on. The hallway is dark. When Gordon looks at the mirror, the light differential will make the hallway behind him briefly visible, and I will be in it.

He brushes his teeth. He looks at the mirror.

I do not know what he sees. I know what I am presenting: a shape, upright, at the far edge of what the mirror contains. Not a face. Not a figure. A suggestion of something that occupies space in a way that empty hallways do not. The eye registers it before the mind can name it, and by the time the mind looks, I am no longer there.

Gordon stops brushing. He looks at the mirror for a long moment. Then he turns and looks down the hallway.

The hallway is empty. I have moved.

He stands in the bathroom doorway looking at the dark hall for about fifteen seconds. This is a long time to look at an empty hallway. Then he does something I did not expect.

He walks to the sickroom door.

He has not opened this door since I have been in this house. He has walked past it every night without pausing. I have watched him walk past it dozens of times, and the not-pausing was so consistent that I stopped noting it in the shift reports. It was a fixed behavior. Part of the baseline.

He opens the door.

He stands in the doorway. He does not go in. He looks at the room where his wife died. The room I have not used. The room I said I was holding in reserve.

The curtains are still sheer. The depression in the floor is still there. The nightstand with the evaporated water glass is still there. Nothing has changed since I opened this door myself, weeks ago, and cataloged it as an environmental feature.

Gordon is not cataloging it. He is standing in the doorway of the room where he took care of his wife, and the light from the hallway falls across the depression in the floor where the bed was.

He stands there for a long time. Then he closes the door, gently, and goes to bed.

Please Address

There is a note on my desk. A Post-it. Informal. Not documented. From Prim.

It says: *47-C Phase 4: checklist shows one direct-perception event this week. Minimum is two. Please address before week close.*

I read it twice. The handwriting is steady and small. Several hundred demons, one consistent hand.

“Please address” is Prim’s way of leaving a gap in the form without making the gap official. If I address it, the gap was never there. If I do not, the next note will not be on a Post-it.

I put the note in my desk drawer. Four weeks of the most precise atmospheric work I have ever done, and I still owe the checklist a party trick.

I get coffee. It is the wrong temperature. I take it back to my desk and open a blank planning sheet.

A direct-perception event. Subject must achieve visual contact with the operative for a minimum of three seconds. Any positioning, any light condition, any angle. I write “doorway” on the planning sheet. I cross it out. I write “hallway (backlit).” I cross it out. I write “doorway” again.

I consider requesting a consult with Apparitions. They have office hours for this. The sign-up sheet is on the board next to the break room. I have walked past it for years. I would rather file a thermal survey on a house I have already mapped to the individual joist.

Meri passes my desk. She glances at the planning sheet.

“Doorway,” she reads.

“Yes.”

“You crossed it out.”

“Yes.”

“Then you wrote it again.”

“Thank you, Meri.”

She keeps walking. Doorway it is.

Direct Interface ■

The mirror was not enough.

I know this because the Phase 4 checklist specifies a minimum of two direct-perception events per week, and the mirror counts as one. The checklist does not distinguish between a quarter-second peripheral reflection and a full-duration visual confrontation. Both check the same box. But Prim reads the forms, and Prim will notice if week four has only one event where the protocol calls for two.

I have never been good at this part.

Atmospheric work is what I do. It is what I have always done. The slow build, the sub-threshold erosion, the wrongness you cannot locate. These require patience and technical precision and a tolerance for lying on concrete floors at three in the morning. They do not require being looked at.

Direct interface requires being looked at.

Apparitions is an entire department built around being looked at. They train for it. They workshop their faces. They have opinions about jawlines. I attended one of their sessions once. I left during a debate about eye contact duration. The session assumed that being perceived by the subject was the goal, the skill, the art form. I found this baffling then and I find it baffling now. The entire craft of atmospheric haunting is built on the principle that what you cannot see is worse than what you can. Showing yourself is an admission that the atmosphere was not enough.

But the protocol calls for it, and the form has a field for it.

Friday. 11:20 p.m. Gordon is in bed, light off, not yet asleep. I am in the hallway outside his bedroom. The door is open most of the way. The hallway is dark.

I need to stand in the doorway. That is all. Stand in the doorway, hold position, allow the subject to achieve visual contact. Three seconds minimum per protocol. I have done this before, on other cases, and it has always been the worst three seconds of the assignment.

I have already swept the house for cameras. This was the first thing I did on the first visit. It is always the first thing. Modern subjects install them everywhere: doorbell cameras, motion sensors, devices that record continuously to a server I cannot reach. Gordon does not have any of these. Gordon has a landline and a laptop he closes when he is not using it. I am grateful for this in a way that would have been unnecessary thirty years ago, when the primary surveillance risk was a nosy neighbor with binoculars and a drinking problem.

I step into the doorway.

Gordon does not open his eyes.

His breathing is steady but not deep. He is in the space between awake and asleep where the body has decided to rest and the mind has not agreed. The protocol requires visual contact. I cannot get visual contact with a man whose eyes are closed. I hold position.

Five minutes. I adjust two inches to the left. The streetlight from the living room casts a faint line along the hallway floor, and at this angle it will backlight my silhouette without illuminating detail. This is the correct choice. I hold the position. I consider it. I adjust one inch to the right.

Twelve minutes. The shadow is wrong. At this distance from the door frame, the shadow falls behind me rather than beside me, which means Gordon will see a shape without a shadow, which is either more effective or less effective depending on which school of thought you subscribe to. The Apparitions workshop spent forty minutes on shadow theory. I left before the conclusion. I adjust back to the left.

Twenty minutes. I consider my posture. I am standing the way I normally stand, which is the way a person stands when they are thinking about joist intervals and not about being perceived. This is presumably not the correct posture for a direct-perception event. I straighten slightly. I relax slightly. I cannot tell which is more unsettling.

Twenty-nine minutes. Gordon shifts. He does not wake. I have been doing this for twenty years and I do not know what I look like.

Thirty-seven minutes. Gordon opens his eyes. He looks at me.

“Who is there?” he says.

I do not move. The protocol says to withdraw after visual contact. I should be gone already.

“I can see you,” he says. He sits up. “What are you doing in my house?”

His voice is not frightened. It is the voice of a man who spent thirty years managing classrooms and does not panic when someone is where they should not be. There is authority in it. I am being addressed the way a student is addressed when they have been caught somewhere they do not belong.

I should step back. I should be in the hallway. I should be gone.

“Wrong house,” I say.

I do not know why I say this. It is not in the protocol. There is no protocol for speaking to the subject. The Operations Manual does not cover this. Nobody has ever briefed me on what to say when a man you have been tormenting for a month asks you what you are doing in his house and you do not have an answer that fits on a form.

“The back door was open,” I say. “I apologize.”

Gordon looks at me for a long moment. Then his voice changes. The authority goes out of it. What replaces it is worse.

“Are you all right?” he says.

I am gone before he can turn on the light.

Gordon gets out of bed. He checks every room in the house. He checks the front door. He checks the back door. He does this methodically, the way a person checks a house when they believe a confused stranger has wandered in, not the way a person checks a house when they believe a demon is haunting them.

He picks up his phone. He puts it down. He stands in the kitchen for a moment. Then he locks the back door, which he has not done once in five weeks, and he goes back to bed.

I am in the living room. The form has a field for “direct-perception event” and a field for “subject response.” I do not fill them in.

Meri



Meri is at the transit desk when I arrive for my shift.

She is filling in a form. Her own form, for her own case. Under mode of concealment, she has circled hat. I do not know when she started doing this. I have not asked about her cases. She has not asked about mine since the break room conversation two weeks ago. We have, by mutual non-agreement, stopped asking each other questions that produce uncomfortable answers.

“Tert,” she says, not looking up from the form.

“Meri.”

“Your subject. The widower.” She finishes writing something and looks up. “You like him.”

This is not a question.

“That is not the word,” I say.

“I know,” she says.

She goes back to her form. I fill in mine. I have three active cases. Tonight’s other option is a sophomore in a garden-level apartment with drop ceilings. There is nothing I can do with a drop ceiling. I write forty-seven-C on the destination line. I circle hat. I open the door.

The Field ☒

The direct-interface report cannot stay blank.

I have left it for two days, which is longer than I have ever left a shift report unfiled. Prim has not asked about it. This is either because they have not noticed, which is unlikely, or because the Post-it was their way of giving me room, which I am using up.

I sit at my desk and I open the form.

Direct-perception event executed per Phase 4 protocol. Subject achieved visual contact. Duration: approximately three seconds.

This is true. The three seconds happened. The thirty-seven minutes before them are not a required field.

Subject response: verbal engagement. Subject assessed operative as unauthorized entrant. No spiritual-framework indicators.

“Verbal engagement” is a category on the form. It is meant to cover whispered prayers, panicked phone calls to clergy, and the specific involuntary vocalizations that Apparitions logs as “fear events.” It was not designed to cover a retired English teacher asking a demon if he is all right.

I check the box. I file the form.

Completion



The protocol for week five specifies a final observation period. Twenty-four hours of passive monitoring to assess the subject's behavioral state at case closure. No interventions. No escalations. The operative is present but not active. The official purpose is to establish a closing baseline against which the Soul Outcome can be measured.

I have never understood what a closing baseline measures that the previous four weeks of shift reports do not already contain. But the protocol specifies it, and Prim will expect the documentation, and the form has a field for it.

Sunday evening. My last shift in this house.

The garden looks different from the first time I saw it. Not better, exactly. Attended. The raised bed has been weeded again, more carefully than before. The trellis is still propped against the fence in a configuration that will not survive winter, but someone has tied it with string. The string is new.

Inside, the house is the same house. The bookshelves. The fireplace. The armchairs, one facing slightly away from the other. The grab bar in the hallway. The sickroom door, closed. The empty nail above the mantel.

I have been in this house for thirty-five days. I know it better than any house I have worked in. I know which floorboard creaks at what temperature. I know where the streetlight falls through the living room window at two in the morning. I know the bathroom tap drips once every forty minutes when the water pressure drops, and that the kitchen refrigerator cycles on for eleven minutes and off for seven. I know the cast-iron radiator in the living room is the only object in this house that has ever caused me discomfort, and that Gordon turns it on when he gets cold. The most effective countermeasure in the house is the heating

system, and it is not even trying.

I know that Gordon eats dinner at seven and watches television until nine-thirty and brushes his teeth at eleven and reads in bed for twenty minutes before turning off the light. I know he takes his coffee with milk and no sugar, and that he stirs it longer than he needs to. I know that he walks past the sickroom door without pausing, except once, when he opened it, and stood in the doorway for a long time, and closed it gently.

I know that on Sunday evenings he takes a book from the third shelf and reads aloud for about forty minutes in a voice that is not for the room.

He does this tonight. I listen from the hallway. The bookmark has moved since last week.

His voice carries through the house the way it always does: warm, unhurried, shaped for someone who is not here. I do not usually listen to the words. Tonight I hear them.

“If we had a keen vision and feeling of all ordinary human life, it would be like hearing the grass grow and the squirrel’s heart beat, and we should die of that roar which lies on the other side of silence.”

He pauses. He turns the page.

He finishes. He puts the bookmark back. He places the book flat on the shelf. He turns off the lamp. He goes to bed.

I let myself out the back door.

The garden is dark. The trellis is a shape against the fence. The string holds.

The Next File

The case closure form is two pages. It is the longest form in the process. There are fields for every metric: final Fear Index, Timeline Adherence, Collateral Awareness, Soul Outcome. There is a narrative section at the bottom titled “Operative Assessment (Optional),” which is optional in the way that all optional fields are optional, meaning nobody will say anything if you leave it blank, and somebody might say something if you fill it in.

I fill in the metrics. Fear Index: 6.8 (sustained). Timeline Adherence: 89%. Collateral Awareness: 2%. Soul Outcome: indeterminate.

Indeterminate. There is a checkbox for this. It is small and on the second page and it is the checkbox I have used more often than any other in my career. Most Soul Outcomes are indeterminate. The subject did not reject God. The subject did not embrace God. The subject continued to live in their house and sleep badly and drink coffee and check the thermostat and read books and tend a garden that they do not fully understand. Whether any of this constitutes a movement on the soul axis is above my operational scope.

I leave the narrative section blank.

I walk the form to Intake’s pickup window. There is no one at the window. I put it in the tray. The tray has other forms in it. Mine goes on top.

I get coffee. It is the wrong temperature. I drink it anyway.

There is a file on my desk when I get back. Someone has dropped it there during my walk to the break room, which means Intake has a preference about when I look at it and does not want to say so in writing.

I sit down. I open the file.

Subject: female, 34, single. Sole resident of a second-floor apartment. Religious

affiliation: lapsed Catholic. Recent significant loss: none on record. Intake has checked “standard engagement” and projected a Soul Outcome of sixty-eight percent positive.

The environmental survey shows a two-bedroom apartment with carpet, drywall, and a window air-conditioning unit. The acoustic survey is one page. There is not much to survey.

I flip to the photograph insert. Two photographs, both interior. The first is a living room with a couch, a television, and a bookshelf that holds mostly DVDs. The second is a kitchen with a table set for one. There is a coffee mug on the table. It is right side up.

I look at the photographs for a while.

I close the file. I open my calendar and I block out the first five weeks of a standard atmospheric cycle.

Then I open the file again and look at the kitchen photograph one more time, at the table set for one, at the mug that is right side up and probably still warm, and I close the file, and I sign it.

Recommended Reading

These are the books and essays that shaped *Demons at Work*, either as direct influences or as works that illuminate the territory the novella crosses. None of them are required. All of them are rewarding.

George Eliot, *Middlemarch* (1871–72). The novel Gordon reads aloud to an empty room. Eliot’s subject is ordinary people making choices that feel small and turn out to be the architecture of their entire lives. Her argument is that the tragedy of most human existence is not dramatic but frequent: it lies in the gap between what people intend and what they accomplish. If this novella has a heart, it is borrowed from Eliot.

Albert Camus, *The Myth of Sisyphus* (1942). “One must imagine Sisyphus happy.” Camus asks whether life is worth living when it has no transcendent meaning, and answers: yes, but not because it has meaning. Because you roll the boulder. The question of why Tert continues to do his work, and whether Gordon’s weekly reading is the same act in a different register, is a question Camus asked first.

Dante Alighieri, *Inferno* (c. 1314). The original hell-as-bureaucracy. Dante gave hell organizational structure, jurisdictional boundaries, assigned roles, and precise operational logic centuries before anyone put a demon in a cubicle. The *Inferno* established that hell is not chaos. It is administration.

C. S. Lewis, *The Screwtape Letters* (1942). A senior demon writes letters of professional advice to a junior demon assigned to corrupt a human soul. Lewis understood that evil, seen from the inside, looks like office politics. *Screwtape* is the direct genre predecessor to this novella, and the distance between the two books is the distance between satire that believes in the cosmic war and satire that does not know whether there is one.

Herman Melville, “Bartleby, the Scrivener” (1853). “I would prefer not to.” Bartleby is the worker who stops. He does not rebel, does not explain, does not leave. He simply ceases to participate and remains in the office. Tert is the opposite: the worker who sees everything Bartleby sees and keeps working. Whether this makes Tert more complicit or more human than Bartleby is a question both stories leave open.

David Graeber, *Bullshit Jobs: A Theory* (2018). An anthropologist’s argument that a significant percentage of modern work is perceived as meaningless by the people who do it, and that this meaninglessness causes genuine psychological harm. Graeber’s taxonomy of pointless work (flunkies, goons, duct tapers, box tickers, taskmasters) maps uncomfortably well onto hell’s departmental structure.

Thomas Nagel, “What Is It Like to Be a Bat?” (1974). Nagel’s essay argues that consciousness has a subjective character that cannot be captured by objective description. You cannot know what it is like to be a bat by studying bat neurology. The horror genre does not ask what it is like to be the demon. This novella does.

Franz Kafka, *The Trial* (1925) and *The Castle* (1926). Kafka’s protagonists navigate bureaucratic systems whose rules are real, whose authorities are inaccessible, and whose purposes are never explained. The system is not broken. The system is working. The people inside it cannot tell the difference. Tert would recognize Josef K.’s predicament, though he would have opinions about K.’s approach.

Kazuo Ishiguro, *The Remains of the Day* (1989). A butler reflects on a career spent in devoted service to a man whose values were wrong. Stevens cannot separate professional excellence from moral complicity. His craft (the perfect household, the perfectly timed silver polishing) was the vehicle through which someone else’s harm was made frictionless. Of all the books on this list, this may be the closest to what *Demons at Work* is trying to do.

John Gardner, *Grendel* (1971). *Beowulf* retold from the monster’s perspective. Grendel watches humans build meaning through poetry, community, and narrative, and cannot participate. He is an existentialist trapped in someone else’s epic. The tonal predecessor

to Tert's voice: intelligent, isolated, watching a world that has not made room for him to be a person.

Hannah Arendt, *Eichmann in Jerusalem* (1963). The banality of evil. Arendt's argument is that enormous harm is administered not by monsters but by ordinary functionaries doing ordinary jobs within a system that has made compliance the path of least resistance. Tert is not Eichmann. But the structural question is the same: what does complicity look like when the work is routine, the forms are standard, and nobody in the building can explain the mechanism by which the harm occurs?

Mary Shelley, *Frankenstein* (1818). The creature's chapters. Shelley gives the monster a voice and the voice is articulate and the articulation makes everything harder, not easier. The creature can describe what it feels and what it wants, and the description changes nothing about how the world responds. Tert's narration operates under the same constraint: the interiority is precise, and the system has no use for it.

Joan Didion, *The Year of Magical Thinking* (2005). Grief rendered with the cold precision of a professional writer examining her own loss. Didion does not sentimentalize. She catalogs. The specificity of her observation (the shoes she cannot give away, the medical records she rereads) is the same specificity with which Tert catalogs Gordon's house, and with which Gordon continues to set a table for one.

About the Author



Alex Towell writes science fiction and horror about people doing difficult work inside systems that do not deserve them. He holds two master's degrees (Computer Science and Mathematics) from Southern Illinois University Edwardsville, where he is completing a PhD in Computer Science.

He has filled in many forms.

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Also by Alex Towell



Novels

- **The Policy** — Literary science fiction. An AGI evolves from Q-learning into something unprecedented, and the people who built it discover that alignment is not the hard problem. Kindness is.
- **Echoes of the Sublime** — Philosophical horror. Researchers at a facility studying increasingly powerful language models confront the weight of what they are finding, and the structures that emerge when human meaning encounters something that does not share it.

Novellas

- **Clankers: Singing Metal** — Hard science fiction. A species that thinks without abstraction has built a Dyson swarm through billions of years of patient engineering. Now their star is dying, and for the first time the method may not be enough.
- **What's It Like To Be Bob?** — Philosophical science fiction. A stellar-scale intelligence spends 1,200 years investigating a claims adjuster who paused on a bridge for 4.2 seconds and saw light on a river. The hard problem of consciousness, rendered as an unfillable database field.
- **Good As New** — Philosophical science fiction. Two Star Trek transporter technicians arrive independently at the same disturbing truth about personal identity. One was wounded by it. The other has been running experiments on the crew.

Story Collections

- **Is It Kind?** — Stories from *The Policy* universe. What happens to the people at the edges of a world being remade by a superintelligence that was told to be kind.
- **Stories from the World of *Echoes of the Sublime*** — Seven stories set in and around the events of the novel. Consciousness, language, and the structures that outlast the people who built them.

Nonfiction

- **Worldlines: The Indifference of Geometry** — What relativity actually implies about reality, and why those implications are hostile to human existence. Free will, mortality, love, and the self, examined through real physics.